

Villa Capra

A Palladian villa that is among the most influential buildings in the history of Western architecture



Standing on a hill outside Vicenza in northern Italy, the Villa Capra, also known as La Rotonda, was designed by Venetian architect Andrea Palladio (1508–1580). It was built as a country house for a high-ranking clergyman, prelate Paolo Almerico, who had returned to Vicenza after a career in the Vatican Court, and its vibrant interior was decorated with spectacular frescoes celebrating Christian virtue.

Harmony and serenity

Begun in 1567, Villa Capra reflects Palladio's profound study of the buildings of ancient Rome. It is an almost perfectly symmetrical structure, with a domed cylindrical central hall surrounded by identical columned porticos, modeled on Roman temples such as the Pantheon (see pp.104–105), on all four sides. As a result, the villa appears balanced and sophisticated from whichever angle it is viewed, and its careful placement in the landscape gives a harmonious view of the "natural theater" surrounding it. Completed after Palladio's death in 1580

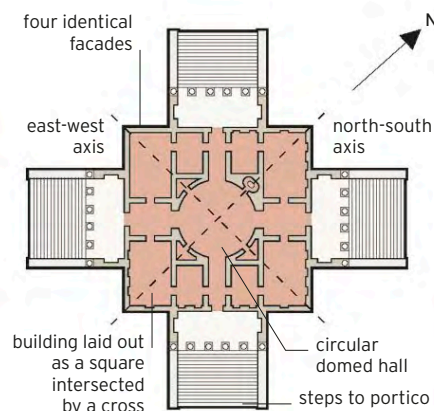
▼ CLASSICAL STYLE

Palladio's inspired use of Classical proportion and natural space made him one of the most successful architects of his time. He built more than 20 villas in the Veneto region.

by his pupil Vincenzo Scamozzi, the building has since been an inspiration to architects across the Western world, who have been fascinated by the perfection of its formal beauty.

PRINCIPLES OF PERFECTION

Palladio's design is based on strict mathematical proportions intended to create a mystic harmony between the elements of the building. The basic floor plan is a circle within a square—forms that symbolized the perfection of the Universe to Renaissance thinkers. The building is precisely oriented so that the north-to-south and east-to-west axes pass through the corners of the square.



THE CITY PALACE

Called a "city in the shape of a palace" by Castiliogne, the palace was already huge when Laurana took over construction in 1464. The Dalmatian architect added the facade with the twin turrets, the courtyard, and other parts of the complex.



PLAN OF THE PALACE

The Ducal Palace was built around a courtyard, with the main living quarters on the first floor, or *piano nobile*, shown here. The facade overlooking the valley had a balcony between twin towers. The Duke's study, the *studiolo*, was a tiny room only 12 ft (3.6 m) wide, but exquisitely decorated with inlaid wooden panels.

